

The Unspoken Alternative: A Counterfactual Argument on the Indispensability of Rhetorical Architecture to the National Socialist Project

The study of history invites, at its margins, a question that professional historians often treat with suspicion but that the discipline cannot entirely suppress: *what if it had not happened?* Counterfactual reasoning is speculative by nature, yet it performs a clarifying function — it forces the analyst to distinguish between events that were structurally inevitable and those that depended on contingent human acts, particularly acts of speech. The words examined in this essay — Adolf Hitler's address at the Bürgerbräukeller on February 27th, 1925, during the formal re-founding of the NSDAP, and Hermann Goering's testimony before the International Military Tribunal at Nuremberg on March 13th, 1946 — occupy radically different moments in the arc of National Socialism, the first at its reconstitution and the second at its postmortem. Yet both are instances in which language did not merely describe political reality but actively constructed it, and the question of what might have resulted from their absence is therefore not idle speculation but a serious inquiry into whether rhetoric itself constituted a load-bearing wall of the entire edifice. This essay argues that had these words not been spoken, the political trajectory of German fascism would have been meaningfully — though not necessarily permanently — altered: the 1925 address was the sine qua non of the NSDAP's reunification under a single charismatic authority, and the 1946 testimony was the foundational act of a revisionist historiography that has contaminated public memory of the regime's origins ever since.

The case of the Neugründung speech is, in counterfactual terms, the more consequential of the two, because the rhetorical situation it addressed was genuinely precarious. When Hitler stood before that audience, the NSDAP as such did not exist. It had been dissolved following the failed putsch of November 1923, and its remnants had fractured into rival successor organizations — the Großdeutsche Volksgemeinschaft under Streicher and Esser on one side, and the parliamentary faction of Buttman, Feder, and Frick on the other (Hitler, "Deutschlands Zukunft und unsere Bewegung" 14). Hitler himself had only recently emerged from Landsberg Prison, his political future entirely uncertain, his authority over the movement no longer axiomatic. The audience before him therefore consisted not of a docile congregation but of rival partisans who had spent nine months in bitter internecine conflict. The exigence was double and urgent: he needed to simultaneously consolidate fractured loyalty around his person and furnish that loyalty with a directional purpose sufficient to override the accumulated grievances of a desolate organization.

Had this speech not been delivered — or, more precisely, had the rhetorical operations it performed not been executed with the precision they were — the most probable immediate outcome would have been the continued fragmentation of the völkisch-nationalist movement into competing factions, none of which possessed the mass base or the ideological coherence necessary to become a serious political force. The speech accomplished something that no organizational memorandum or backroom negotiation could have achieved: it performed, before

a live audience of three thousand, the act of reconciliation itself. Hitler's rhetoric did not argue that the factions should reunite; it enacted the reunification in real time, closing with the physical spectacle of former rivals publicly clasping hands beneath the old banner ("Deutschlands Zukunft" 27-28). The address constructed an enemy — the Jew, rendered as a singular typological figure operating simultaneously behind both the bourgeoisie and the Marxist left — whose existence made internal disputes not merely petty but structurally incomprehensible. If the same hidden architect manipulates both sides of the political spectrum, then the only rational response is total consolidation against that architect, and any residual quarrel among nationalists becomes, in the logic of the speech, a form of unwitting collaboration with the enemy. The consolidation of the enemy produced the consolidation of the movement; neither could have occurred without the other, and both were accomplished through the rhetorical apparatus of a single evening.

Without this reunification, the NSDAP would have entered the late Weimar period as one of several small nationalist splinter parties, lacking the organizational discipline, the singular leadership, and the mass-mobilization apparatus that distinguished it from competitors like the DNVP or the Stahlhelm. The party's subsequent electoral ascent — from twelve Reichstag seats in 1928 to 230 in July 1932 — depended on the infrastructure of a unified movement with a single charismatic center. It is, of course, impossible to assert that no other figure or no other speech could have accomplished what Hitler accomplished on that evening. But the structural conditions of the moment — the depth of the factional resentment, the need for a figure who could credibly claim to stand above the quarrel rather than within it, the requirement that reconciliation be performed publicly and emotionally rather than negotiated privately — made the specific rhetorical form of the Neugründung address something closer to a necessary condition than a mere accelerant. The words were not decorative; they were architectural.

The counterfactual surrounding Goering's Nuremberg testimony operates on a different register entirely. The Third Reich had already fallen; the question was no longer what political order would emerge but rather what historical narrative would survive. When Goering took the witness stand on the afternoon of March 13th, 1946, he entered a rhetorical situation without precedent — a former head of state testifying under oath before an international tribunal, facing charges that carried the death penalty, with the historical record itself as his ultimate audience. His immediate interlocutors were the judges and counsel of the International Military Tribunal, but Goering was manifestly performing for posterity. His testimony undertook a systematic revisionist project through three interlocking strategies: the construction of a reluctant-patriot ethos, the narrativization of political radicalization as intellectual discovery, and the reframing of ideological extremism as synthesis (Nuremberg Trial Proceedings Vol. 9, Day 80, 236-238).

The reluctant-patriot ethos was built through a careful architecture of refusal. Goering listed his war decorations — the Iron Cross, the Zähringer Löwe, the Hohenzollern, and the Pour le Mérite — establishing military honor as the ground of his credibility before mentioning the Nazi party at all. He then structured his narrative so that he was always refusing things: he "rejected the invitation to enter the Reichswehr," went to Munich "as a spectator," and attended Hitler's

meeting only "to hear what he had to say" (Nuremberg Trial Proceedings Vol. 9, Day 80, 236–237). The entry into politics is thus reframed as a moment of recognition rather than recruitment — Hitler did not create Goering's beliefs but merely voiced them, speaking "word for word as if from my own soul" (237). Most critically, Goering described National Socialism not as the extreme right-wing ideology the prosecution had spent months documenting but as a philosophical synthesis: "the unity of the two concepts of nationalism on the one hand and socialism on the other," combining the nationalism of the bourgeois world with the socialism of the Marxist world into a new and rational middle position (238). The rhetorical function of this framing was not to persuade the judges — Goering almost certainly knew it would not — but to deposit into the trial record an alternative origin narrative for future audiences.

Had this testimony not been given, the Nuremberg proceedings would have lacked their most articulate and strategically coherent defense of the regime's ideological foundations. The prosecution's narrative — that National Socialism was a criminal conspiracy from its inception, driven by aggressive intent and sustained by terror — would have stood substantially less contested in the documentary record. This matters not because Goering's account was truthful, but because it was rhetorically formidable enough to furnish subsequent apologists with a readymade framework. The notion that the NSDAP originated as a reasonable response to Weimar's failures, that its leaders were patriots rather than opportunists, and that its ideology represented a moderate synthesis rather than a radical extreme — these ideas did not originate with Goering, but his testimony gave them their most polished and publicly accessible articulation within the single most important legal proceeding of the twentieth century. Without it, the postwar historiographical battle over the meaning of National Socialism would have proceeded on somewhat different terrain. The revisionist camp would have lacked the testimony of the regime's second-ranking figure offering, under oath and in full public view, a coherent counter-narrative to the prosecution's case.

It must be conceded that counterfactual arguments of this nature can never achieve certainty. Historical causation is overdetermined; the forces that produced the NSDAP's rise and the forces that produced postwar revisionism were structural as well as contingent, economic as well as rhetorical, institutional as well as personal. Other speakers might have reunified the movement in 1925; other defendants might have mounted similar defenses at Nuremberg. But the argument here is not that these words were the sole cause of what followed — it is that they were, in their specific moments, irreplaceable performances that accomplished what no alternative available at the time could have accomplished with equal force. The Neugründung address did not merely announce the party's re-founding; it performed the act of consolidation that made re-founding possible. Goering's testimony did not merely defend his actions; it constructed a revisionist historiography that would outlive him. In both cases, the words were not reflections of a reality that existed independently of them — they were the instruments through which that reality was brought into being. To ask what would have happened without them is therefore to ask what would have happened if the foundation had not been laid, and the answer, in both cases, is that the structure built upon it would have been, at minimum, substantially different — weaker, later,

and less coherent — even if the underlying forces that demanded such a structure remained in place.

Works Cited

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